
“It **rekindled** the few expiring
embers of freedom, and
revived within me a **sense of**
my own manhood.”

FREDERICK DOUGLASS, ON FIGHTING BACK AGAINST FARMER
EDWARD COVEY, 1834

The son of an enslaved woman and an unknown white man, Douglass was born Frederick Augustus Washington Bailey in Maryland. He rarely saw his mother and lived in slave quarters until he was eight. In 1826, he was sent by his owner to serve Hugh Auld in Baltimore. Auld's wife taught him to read but her husband halted the lessons, claiming that education gave slaves dangerous ideas. Frederick, however, continued to read in secret.

At 15, he was sent to the country to work for Edward Covey. Frequently beaten by this infamous “slave-breaker,” he fought back, risking death. In January 1836 he made his first escape attempt, but ended up in jail. Two years later, while working in a Baltimore shipyard, he succeeded. With money loaned from his fiancée Anna Murray, a free Black woman from the city, he traveled northward to New Bedford, Massachusetts. There he settled, marrying Murray and changing his name to Douglass.

While Douglass was impressed with New Bedford, he was aware of the segregation in the churches. White employers refused to hire him and he was forced to take menial jobs. He became a preacher at the local Zion Methodist Church and a subscriber to the abolitionist newspaper, *The Liberator*, published by William Lloyd Garrison, founder of the American Anti-Slavery Society. “The paper became my meat and drink. My soul was set all on fire.” Joining the local chapter of the Anti-Slavery Society, Douglass published his first